

# Jenna B. Baljunas

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## Education

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- Ph.D.**      **Integrative Biology (IBIO) and Ecology, Evolution, & Behavior (EEB)**  
*Michigan State University, East Lansing, MI (8/25-current)*
- B.S.**      **Environmental Science, Botany Minor**  
*Chatham University, Pittsburgh, PA (8/20-12/23)*  
GPA: 3.94 / Summa Cum Laude, Honors Program

## Experience

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### *Research*

**Ph.D. Researcher – Spatial and Community Ecology (SpaCE) Lab**

*Michigan State University, East Lansing, MI (8/25-current)*

Advisor: Dr. Phoebe Zarnetske

Committee: Drs. Lydia Beaudrot, Alisha Shah, & Dirk Colbry

**Plant Ecology Intern**

*Archbold Biological Station, Highlands County, FL (9/24-5/25)*

Collected demographic and community data on rare and endemic plant species to support long-term datasets and conservation efforts. Independently investigated seed predation as a driver to plant population dynamics.

**Seasonal Field Ornithologist**

*National Aviary, Northwestern Pennsylvania (6/24-8/24)*

Assessed avian forest community responses to silviculture with mist netting protocols and vegetation surveys.

**Field Technician**

*Chatham University Eden Hall Campus, Gibsonia, PA (9/23-12/23)*

Conducted meta-analysis and field study on endozoochorous seed dispersal by white-tailed deer.

**NSF-REU Position in Ecohydrology of Tropical Montane Forests**

*Texas A&M University, College Station, TX & San Ramon, Costa Rica (5/23-8/23)*

Conducted soil, vegetation, and topographical surveys to study tropical forest community dynamics.

### *Teaching*

**Supplemental Instructor – Quantitative Ecology (SUS404/SUS404L)**

*Chatham University, Pittsburgh, PA (8/23-12/23)*

**Peer Educator – General Chemistry (CHM107/108) & Integrative Biology (SUS201)**  
*Chatham University, Pittsburgh, PA (8/21-4/23)*

*Mentorship*

2025-2026      Lab undergraduates: Caroline Roche, Liz Bauer, Addison Hoddinott, Vivian Smith, Olive Graves, Elliot Palmer, Jamie Soehl

**Grants & Fellowships**

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2026-2030      National Science Foundation (NSF) *Graduate Research Fellowship (GRFP)* – **\$159,000**  
2026            MSU ICER *Open Scholarship Fellowship Extension* – **\$400**  
2025            MSU ICER *Open Scholarship Fellowship* – **\$200**  
2025            MSU *College of Natural Science (CNS) Recruitment Fellowship* – **\$34,000**  
2024            *La Prima Student Fund* – **\$585** (received for Baljunas et al. (2024). *Freshwater Science*.)

**Peer-Reviewed Publications**

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4. **Baljunas, J.B.**, Anderson, H.J., Gerstner, B.E., Bills, P., Zarnetske, P.L. [*in prep*]. The Scale-Dependent Relationships of Fruiting Plants and Frugivores in Tropical Andes Forests. Target journal: *Global Ecology and Biogeography*.
3. Kaushal, S.S., Mon, A.E., Slaughter W.M., Likens, G.E., Ravinsky-Gray, Y., Utz, R.M., Mayer, P.M., Grant, S.B., Yannayon, S., **Baljunas, J.B.**, Kinjalka, K., Garg, A., Zhu, M., Fischel, M., Duan, S., Shelton, S.A., Newcomer Johnson, T., Lastner, A.J., Dann A.B., Rippey, M.A., Graham, A., Melton, C.G., Mullen, J., Hickey, K.M., Bickerstaff, K.R.S., Martinchick, M., Evardo, O., Clark, R., Brown, S., Toibero, S., Lee, Y., Bhide, S. [*in review*]. Human perturbation of global element cycles and chain reaction risk. *Biogeochemistry*.
2. Kaushal, S.S., Shelton, S., Mayer, P.M., Kellmayer, B., Utz, R.M., Reimer, J.E., **Baljunas, J.**, Bhide, S.V., Mon, A., Rodriguez-Cardona, B.M., Grant, S.B., Newcomer-Johnson, T.A., Malin, J.T., Shatkay, R.R., Collison, D.C., Papageorgiou, K., Escobar, J., Rippey, M., Likens, G., Najjar, R.G., Mejia, A.I., Lassiter, A., Li, M., Chant, R.J. (2025). Freshwater faces a warmer and saltier future from headwaters to coasts: climate risks, saltwater intrusion, and biogeochemical chain reactions. *Biogeochemistry*, 168(2), 31.
1. **Baljunas, J.B.\***, Betts, J.T.\*, Utz, R.M., Román-Heracleo, J., and Springer, M. (2024). Mesohabitat affinities of benthic macroinvertebrates in protected lowland rainforest streams of southeast Nicaragua. *Freshwater Science*, 43(4), 453-465

\*-Authors contributed equally to this effort.

## Scientific Communication

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### *Talks*

2. “Banking on it: is seed bank predation a driver of plant population dynamics?” – *Intern Seminar at Archbold Biological Station (5/29/25)*
1. “Soil characteristic response with trees to topographic variation in a premontane rainforest” – *Botanical Society of Western Pennsylvania meeting (4/8/24)*

### *Poster Presentations*

7. **Baljunas, J.**, Anderson, H.J., Gerstner, B.E., Bills, P., Kapsar, K., Zarnetske, P.L. “The Scale-Dependent Relationships of Fruiting Plants and Frugivores in Tropical Andes Forests” – *Ecology, Evolution, & Behavior (EEB) Symposium, Michigan State University, MI (5/5/26)*
6. **Baljunas, J.**, Cahill, A., Dunnebacke, A., Moore, G., Brumbelow, K., Smith, P. “Soil Characteristic Response with Trees to Topographic Variation in a Premontane Rainforest” – *American Geophysical Union (AGU) conference, San Francisco, CA (12/11/23)*
5. **Baljunas, J.**, Cahill, A., Dunnebacke, A., Moore, G., Brumbelow, K., Smith, P. “Tree Distributions and Responses in Relation to Soil Characteristic and Topographic Differences in a Premontane Rainforest” – *Pennsylvania Botany Symposium, State College, PA (10/20/23)*
4. **Baljunas, J.**, Cahill, A., Dunnebacke, A., Moore, G., Brumbelow, K., Smith, P. “Soil Characteristic Response with Trees to Topographic and Slope Position Differences in a Premontane Rainforest” – *LAUNCH Symposium, College Station, TX (8/2/23)*
3. **Baljunas, J.**, Utz, R., Betts, J. “Analysis of Macroinvertebrate Habitat Preferences in Pristine Rainforest Streams of the Rama-Kriol Territory, Nicaragua” – *Mid-Atlantic ESA Chapter Meeting, University of Delaware, DE (3/1/23)*
2. **Baljunas, J.**, DiCianna, M., Gregoris, K., Racioppo, H. “Exploration of Microbial Diversity in a Western Pennsylvania Temperate Peatland” – *Research Day, Chatham University, PA (12/9/22)*
1. **Baljunas, J.**, DiCianna, M., Morgan, K., Racioppo, H. “Population Increase of Bird Species in Pittsburgh” – *Research Day, Chatham University, PA (12/9/21)*.

### *Media*

**Baljunas, J.** (2025, May 28). Approach to the encroach: drone technology and its applications for land management. *Highlands News-Sun*, 8C.

### Workshops

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**ESIL Innovation Summit – AI for Sustainability: Translating Environmental Data into Decisions** – *University of Colorado, Boulder (5/12-5/14/26)*

## Service & Outreach

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### **Museum Volunteer (Botany and Section of Birds)**

*Carnegie Museum of Natural History, Pittsburgh, PA (10/22-12/23)*

Mounted and digitized plant specimens for Mid-Atlantic and tropical Africa databases; inventoried and managed bird specimen collections.

### **Preserve Monitoring with the Nature Conservancy of PA/ DE**

*Dick and Nancy Eales Preserve, Moosic Mountain, PA (6/22-8/22)*

Independently documented and identified vegetation at a restoration site.

### **Society for Ecological Restoration Member**

*Chatham University Eden Hall Campus, Gibsonia, PA (8/21-12/23)*

Assisted and led campus habitat restoration initiatives; held President (2023) and Plant Specialist (2022) officer positions.

### **Organic Production Apprentice**

*Chatham University Eden Hall Campus, Gibsonia, PA (10/20-12/23)*

Assisted and maintained sustainable crop production at the Eden Hall Farm; conducted educational outreach and led hands-on experiences in sustainable agriculture.

## Skills

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### **Technical**

*R, R Studio, R Markdown, GitHub, HPC coding, CyVerse, ArcGIS, GISOnline, ArcGIS Field Maps, ImageJ*

### **Field / Lab**

*Vegetation surveying, plant demography, avian surveying (mist netting, processing and banding birds, point counts, transect surveys), microscopy, soil analysis (texture, bulk density, moisture, DNA extraction), herbarium collection and mounting, electrofishing, tool usage (loppers, chainsaws, and machetes)*